

Selection of levels of prevention.

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This article outlines the advantages and disadvantages of universal and targeted intervention programs. Two advantages of universal programs are the absence of labeling and stigmatization, and the inclusion of the middle class which makes it more likely that the program will be well run. Two disadvantages are that they are unappealing to the public and politicians, and they may have their greatest effect on those at lowest risk. Targeted programs have the potential of addressing problems early on, and are potentially efficient if targeting can be done accurately. Disadvantages include difficulties around screening and the possibility of labeling and stigmatization. The argument is put forth that what is needed to reduce the immense burden of suffering from child and adolescent psychiatric disorders is the optimal mix of universal, targeted, and clinical programs carried out in the context of a civic community. There will always be trade-offs among these strategies, and the elements of the combination will change as knowledge accumulates.